

THE EMPEROR WHO WOULD NOT KNEEL

Chapter 1 — “The Last Breath”

Format: Traditional right-to-left manga script. Read panels right-to-left, top-to-bottom.

Black-and-white. Heavy ink shadow, cinematic negative space, screentone.

Approx. 22 pages.

PAGE 1

Panels: 3 (silent page)

Panel 1 (wide, full-width top)

An empty plain of winter grass under a colorless sky. Long grass bends in a single direction. No banners. No figures. Only wind made visible in the sway of the blades.

SFX (thin, drawn-out): hyoooo

Panel 2 (narrow horizontal, center)

Closer on the grass. The blades bend further — then, at the edge of the panel, they begin to still, as if the wind is being switched off.

SFX (fading): ...hyoo...

Panel 3 (wide, bottom — pure negative space)

The grass has gone completely flat and motionless. Total stillness. A single sheet of white with the faintest horizon line.

No dialogue.

PAGE 2

Panels: 4 (silent page)

Panel 1 (large, top)

Cut to black. Extreme close on a closed human eye in heavy shadow. Weathered skin. A scar or two. This is EGRIS, though we do not know it yet.

No dialogue.

Panel 2 (narrow)

The eye opens. Reflected in it: not sky, but a vast dark height without stars.

No dialogue.

Panel 3 (narrow)

His cheek against smooth black stone. Our POV is low, along the floor — the stone stretches away, polished like a blade.

SFX (faint): ...

Panel 4 (wide, bottom)

Wide low shot: EGRIS lies fallen on an endless black stone floor. He does NOT move to rise. His eyes

are open, already scanning. A man who wakes on strange ground and moves too soon has already given something away.
No dialogue.

PAGE 3

Panels: 4

Panel 1

Close on EGRIS's empty hands, palms up on the black stone. No bow. No knife. No sword.
NARRATION (box): No weapon. They had taken even that.

Panel 2

His wrists. Plain gray cloth where there should have been a warlord's silk. Clean. Thin. Wrong.
No dialogue.

Panel 3 (tight on his face — a flicker of memory, drawn as faint ghost-lines behind him)

Ghost-images bleed at the panel edges: a tightening chest, faces at the edge of a bed, a son speaking too softly, mouth open around words we cannot hear.
NARRATION (box): A tightness in the chest. The taste of iron. A son, speaking too softly to answer.

Panel 4 (narrow, black)

Solid black panel.
NARRATION (box): Then nothing.

PAGE 4

Panels: 1 (FULL-PAGE SPLASH — page-turn reveal)

EGRIS sits up — and the plain is revealed to be CROWDED. Thousands upon thousands of dead cover the black stone to the horizon. Men in rusted mail, women in white burial cloth, children clutching things that are not there, broken-crowned kings, beggars, priests, farmers, soldiers from a hundred eras. The composition overwhelms — Egris small, seen from behind, one lone standing intention amid a sea of the fallen.
Most of them face one direction.
Most of them kneel.
No dialogue.

PAGE 5

Panels: 2

Panel 1 (large, top — the far reveal)

At the far end of the plain: TWO COLOSSAL GATES. Distance does not shrink them. LEFT gate — white metal, no hinge, no lock, a seam of pale light running up into the dark height. RIGHT gate — blacker than the plain itself, crossed with iron ribs, faint cracks pulsing with slow light.
NARRATION (box): Two gates. And distance meant nothing to either.

Panel 2 (wide, bottom)

The kneeling dead in the foreground, foreheads to the stone, facing the gates. Egris stands among them, the only vertical line in a field of bowed backs.

No dialogue.

PAGE 6**Panels: 4****Panel 1**

An OLD MAN kneels beside Egris, tears cutting tracks through the grime on his face. He glances left toward the white gate.

OLD MAN (whisper): "Heaven."

Panel 2

He glances right, toward the black gate. His whisper cracks.

OLD MAN (whisper): "Hell."

Panel 3 (tight on Egris, expression unreadable, studying both gates)

NARRATION (box): A choice between two masters was not freedom.

Panel 4

The OLD MAN cranes up at the standing Egris, terrified for him.

OLD MAN: "You must kneel."

Egris says nothing.

PAGE 7**Panels: 3****Panel 1** (large)

EGRIS stands fully — deliberate, unhurried. A ripple of unease moves through the nearest dead. Heads begin to turn.

SFX (soft, spreading): ...murmur...

Panel 2 (row of faces reacting)

Faces in the crowd — some turn away, some stare with dawning recognition. Fear that was already there, now finding a name.

NARRATION (box): A name could travel farther than any army. Even here.

Panel 3 (wide)

EGRIS begins to walk toward the space between the gates. The crowd opens before him — quickly, carefully, unwilling to touch him. No guard moves to stop him.

No dialogue.

PAGE 8**Panels: 3**

Panel 1 (large)

Egris at the center of the plain now, small against the two enormous gates rising ahead. He stops.
No dialogue.

Panel 2 (detail, white gate)

Close on the white gate's surface. Beneath the light, countless faint shapes — faces, or hands raised in welcome, pressing up from within.

SFX (soft, like water on stone): sssshhh

Panel 3 (detail, black gate)

Close on the black gate's iron ribs. Something behind them MOVES — arranging, rearranging itself. From beyond: no cries at all.

NARRATION (box): No screaming came from the dark gate. That silence was worse.

PAGE 9**Panels: 2****Panel 1** (large, top)

The seam of light in the white gate widens. Pale light spills across the black stone and stops precisely at Egris's feet. Every prayer in the crowd stops at once.

VOICE (from the white gate, lettered clean and weightless): "Egris."

Panel 2 (large, bottom)

Within the light stands a ROBED FIGURE of brightness — no clear face, only the suggestion of one: calm, patient, older than mountains. Egris, tiny before it, does not lower his eyes.

WHITE FIGURE: "You have come far."

PAGE 10**Panels: 3****Panel 1** (large — page energy shifts hard)

From the BLACK gate: laughter. It rolls across the plain like thunder trapped underground. Red light spreads through the iron ribs.

SFX (deep, cracking): GRAHAHAHA

Panel 2

A SECOND FIGURE steps into view — sharp where the first is soft, grinning where the first is still, eyes burning like coals set in a grave.

DARK FIGURE: "Far?"

DARK FIGURE: "He has only arrived."

Panel 3 (wide, low — the crowd bends even lower)

The dead press their foreheads harder to the stone. Only Egris remains upright, a single standing figure between two towering powers.

No dialogue.

PAGE 11

Panels: 4

Panel 1 (tight on Egris)

For the first time since waking, Egris feels the weight of attention that cannot be measured in men or walls or rivers. His jaw sets. He does not look away.

NARRATION (box): He had met men who demanded obedience before offering reward. He had met smiling messengers who came just before an ultimatum.

Panel 2

The WHITE FIGURE raises one hand toward him.

WHITE FIGURE: "He is mine."

Panel 3

The DARK FIGURE's grin widens, teeth like a grave-fire.

DARK FIGURE: "No. He is mine."

Panel 4 (wide, bottom — page-turn tension)

Both colossal figures step forward at once. Their light and shadow close in from either side of the tiny standing man.

SFX (twin, heavy): DMMM.

No dialogue.

PAGE 12

Panels: 1 (near-splash)

Held wide: Egris at the exact center, bathed half in cold white light, half in guttering red. The two crowns of the powers not yet offered — but the composition already frames him as the prize in a tug-of-war between two enormous hands reaching from opposite edges of the page. His face is calm. Calculating. Unbowed.

NARRATION (box, lower corner): They had already decided he belonged to one of them.

NARRATION (box): He had decided nothing of the kind.

— END OF CHAPTER 1 —

SCRIPT NOTES (for artist / letterer)

- **Reading direction:** Right-to-left. Panel 1 sits at top-right of every page.
- **This chapter is shorter (12 pages)** — it is a cold-open / prologue chapter. Let the silence and negative space of Pages 1–3 breathe; do not rush to the crowd reveal.
- **Page 4 is the first big page-turn reveal** — keep Page 3's final panel black so the crowd of the dead lands with full weight when the page turns.
- **The two gates** should be drawn at genuinely oppressive scale — distance must not shrink them. Egris is always a small vertical line against them.
- **The white power = soft, luminous, faceless; the dark power = sharp, jagged, grinning.** Contrast their linework: smooth flowing lines vs. broken angular hatching.

- **Egris never kneels, never widens his eyes in fear.** His resistance is posture, not expression. Keep him readable but controlled.
- **Do not letter the powers' voices in normal balloons** — white figure: weightless, borderless text; dark figure: heavy, cracked balloons.
- **Ends on a hook**, not a resolution — the crowns and the refusal belong to Chapter 2.